

my life. (And for Jack it was pretty special too when I visited him one more time and handed him a copy of his life story.)

From that day I had a new appreciation of how good I had it . . . and I learned one of the crucial lessons about ‘breaking the brat’:

Happiness doesn’t come from stuff—it comes from helping other people.

The hunger games

So, is the answer to frog march your testy teen down to the oldies’ home and get them to churn out a biography?

Actually, I could think of worse things. There’s a lot of wisdom in those places, and a lot of lonely people.

However, after years of thinking about how to engineer a similar experience for my kids, I’ve stumbled onto something that’s pretty simple, but incredibly powerful.

Hunger.

Stay with me here. See, in order for your kids to really learn about giving and happiness it needs to be real.

For kids, food and hunger are real (like, every day on returning home from school).

So your kids are going to give food to people who need it.

‘Giving *food*? In Australia?’

‘Aren’t we one of the wealthiest countries on earth?’

Yes.

‘And aren’t we also one of the most obese nations on earth?’

Yes, we’re a bunch of teletubbies. In fact, we guzzle so many gallons of fizzy drink the Government is considering a ‘sugar tax’ to try to slow us down.

Yet here’s our nation’s hidden secret: